



Introduction: How to Use This Guide

This guide is written for teachers marking IBDP Biology Internal Assessments to IB moderation standards. It is not a simplified summary of the IB rubric — it is a practical marking companion that tells you what to look for, what is commonly over-awarded, and how to write ManageBac comments that will survive moderation.

The single most important principle

Start every criterion at 3 (Achieving) and adjust up or down based on explicit evidence in the student's work.

Do not award marks for what the student might have meant. Award marks for what is demonstrably present on the page.

- Score anchors and descriptors for all four criteria (RD, DA, C, E)
- The most commonly over-awarded scores at each criterion, with reasons
- Moderator red flags — specific issues that trigger downward moderation
- ManageBac comment templates for each score band
- A pre-submission checklist for marking consistency

Criterion 1: Research Design (RD)

Research Design assesses whether the student has designed a valid, focused, and replicable scientific investigation.

Score Anchors

Score	Descriptor	Moderation Note
1–2	Research question present but vague or unmeasurable. Variables partially identified. Method incomplete or unworkable.	<i>Award 1–2 only if major structural components are absent. Rare in submitted work.</i>
3	The research question is clear and measurable. IV, DV and CVs identified. The method is present and mostly reproducible but lacks full justification.	<i>The most common legitimate award. The method works but relies on reader inference for some steps.</i>
4	RQ is focused and biologically specific. All variables operationalised with units. The method is justified and clearly reproducible.	<i>Do not award 4 unless variables are operationalised (not just named) and at least one methodological choice is explicitly justified.</i>
5–6	RQ shows genuine scientific sophistication. The method is fully justified, could be replicated precisely, and demonstrates independent thinking in design.	<i>Reserve 5–6 for designs that show real independence — non-standard methodology, self-derived protocols, or sophisticated variable control.</i>



Most Commonly Over-Awarded

RD over-award: 4 when answer is 3

Teachers frequently award 4 when the student names all three variable types but does not operationalise them with units and methods.

Check: Does the student say HOW temperature will be controlled, at what value, measured how, with what instrument? If not, it is a 3.

Moderator Red Flags — RD

- Variables listed without units or measurement method
- H_0 and H_1 absent (required from score 4 upward)
- Sample size below $n = 5$ per IV level
- Method not replicable without clarification
- Scaffold prompts left visible in the document
- Research question contains the answer implied within it

ManageBac Comment Templates — RD

RD Score 3 — Template

The research question is clearly stated and biologically relevant, and the independent and dependent variables are identified. However, the controlled variables are listed without sufficient operationalisation — the method by which each will be maintained is not specified with units or procedure. The methodology is present and broadly reproducible but lacks explicit justification for key procedural choices. To improve, the student should operationalise all controlled variables with specific values and explain why key methodological decisions were made.

RD Score 4 — Template

The research question is focused and biologically specific, and all three variable types are operationalised with appropriate units. The methodology is clearly justified and sufficiently detailed for independent replication. H_0 and H_1 are both stated correctly. To reach the highest score bands, the student should demonstrate greater independence in design and ensure the protocol could be reproduced with no ambiguity.

Criterion 2: Data Analysis (DA)

Data Analysis is the criterion where marks are most frequently lost and most frequently over-awarded. The critical threshold is the presence of inferential statistics with a correctly interpreted p-value.